

News Weekly

Robots equipped with fingernails are capable of gripping slender edges.

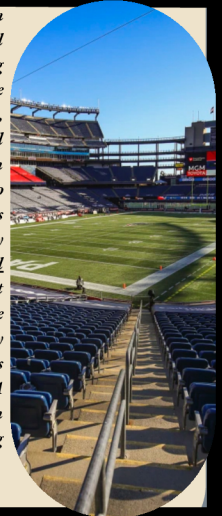
Researchers have designed a new three-fingered robotic hand whose digits come with a rigid fingernail on soft material. The design gives the robotic hand the ability to peel fruit, open containers with lids and pick up flat objects, the team posted to arXiv.org February 5. The results offer a glimpse at the kinds of real-world chores and industrial handling tasks the robot could do.

The tips of most conventional robotic hands have a soft pad on a rigid structure, giving the fingertip a squarish shape. The new robot fingertips have a soft material wrapped around the finger "skeleton," with a rigid structure on top, giving the tip an oval shape, more like our fingers. "A square shape only adapts well to forces coming straight on, but our design can also respond flexibly to twisting or side forces," says mechanical engineer Dong Ho Kang of the University of Texas at Austin. (Source: Science News)



World Cup games at risk after DHS delays in delivering federal grants

Seven FIFA World Cup games that were set to be held in Massachusetts are in question after a delay in federal funding left a small town fearful it might be stuck paying millions in security costs. The seven games are set to be played at Gillette Stadium in the town of Foxborough, Massachusetts, one of 11 U.S. cities that are hosting World Cup games this summer. But the town, which is in metropolitan Boston, has to approve licenses for the games to be held. Its Select Board is reluctant to do that after funds the U.S. government promised to help guarantee security were delayed. More than \$600 million was aside in federal grant money in last year's "One Big Beautiful Bill" budget to assist the cities hosting the World Cup. The funds were supposed to be distributed through the Federal Emergency Management Agency by Jan. 30, according to the agency's website. But the cities have yet to receive the money. FEMA said in a statement it shared with NBC News that it was in the final stages of awarding the grants when its funding lapsed last month. (Source: NBC News)



Scientists just created chocolate honey packed with surprising health perks

Researchers at the State University of Campinas (UNICAMP) in São Paulo, Brazil, have developed a groundbreaking product by blending native bee honey with cocoa bean shells. Highlighted in ACS Sustainable Chemistry & Engineering, this creation can be consumed or used in foods and cosmetics. The team used honey from native bees to naturally extract beneficial compounds from cocoa shells, a byproduct often discarded in chocolate production. These compounds, like theobromine and caffeine, are linked to heart health. The ultrasound-assisted process boosted the honey's phenolic compounds, enhancing its antioxidant and anti-inflammatory effects, and improved its ability to absorb beneficial compounds without synthetic solvents. This chocolate-infused honey, rich in antioxidants and natural stimulants, showcases the potential of local biodiversity and green chemistry in food production, with applications in gourmet foods and cosmetics. (Source: Science Daily and Digg)



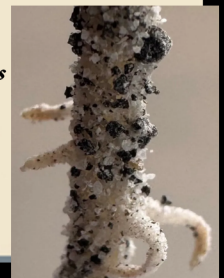
Iran will not compete at Milano Cortina Winter Games, says IPC

Iran will not participate in the Milano Cortina 2026 Paralympic Winter Games, as announced by the International Paralympic Committee on Friday. The ongoing conflict in the Middle East has made it impossible for the country's sole athlete to travel. The National Paralympic Committee of Iran had been preparing to send Abolfazl Khatibi Mianaei, a distinguished athlete, to compete in two Para cross-country skiing events on March 10 and 11. However, due to the geopolitical situation and travel restrictions, the committee decided to withdraw, ending their aspirations for this year's games. (Source: Reuters)



Chickpeas can grow in moon dirt and make seeds

Teaching lunar inhabitants to grow food is crucial for NASA's Artemis program aiming for long-term Moon habitation. Lunar regolith presents challenges, being hazardous, nutrient-poor, and containing toxic metals. Although some plants grew during Apollo missions, they faced stress and toxicity. Researchers Atkin and Santos explored using arbuscular mycorrhizal fungi to improve plant growth in lunar soil. Their experiments with chickpeas showed that plants thrived in lunar regolith simulant mixed with vermicompost, with fungi-treated plants exhibiting increased longevity. The team plans further tests to develop stable lunar soil for crop cultivation and assess chickpea safety.



Paralympic Leaderboard Rankings

er	NPC :	G ↓	S	B	
1	CHN	8	5	3	16
2	UKR	3	2	5	10
3	AUT	2	0	0	2
4	CAN	1	3	2	6
5	USA	1	3	1	5
6	FRA	1	2	0	3
7	GER	1	1	5	7

	2		6	4	3	7	8	5
5	6		1				4	2
					7			
6		4			5			
9	3			6		4	5	7
7	5	2			1	8		6
		3		5			7	
		5	2	3	6			4
			7				2	3

Penne Arrabita

This spicy Italian Penne Arrabbiata is homemade in 20 minutes! It makes a great vegetarian dish, served with fresh parmesan, basil and parsley.

- Ingredients
- ☐ 1 pound penne rigate
- ☐ 3 Tablespoons olive oil
- ☐ 3 cloves garlic
- ☐ 1/4 teaspoon crushed red pepper flakes, depending on how spicy you want it
- ☐ 1 28 ounce can whole peeled tomatoes, (or 1 1/2 cups fresh chopped tomatoes)
- ☐ 2 Tablespoons tomato paste
- ☐ 6 fresh basil leaves, chopped
- ☐ 1/2 cup freshly grated parmesan cheese, (or pecorino cheese), for topping
- ☐ 1/3 cup fresh chopped parsley, (finely chopped), for topping

- Instructions
- Cook pasta in a large pot of boiling water, according to package instructions, until tender.
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 - Meanwhile, heat olive oil in a large skillet over medium heat. Add garlic and crushed red pepper; cook, stirring for 30 seconds.
 - Add tomatoes, crushing them roughly with the back of a wooden spoon, and tomato paste. Bring to a simmer over low heat and cook for 5-10 minutes. Remove from heat and add fresh chopped basil.
 - When pasta is cooked, drain the water and add it to the sauce. Toss well. Taste and add more red pepper flakes or salt and pepper, if needed.
 - Serve immediately topped with a generous portion of grated pecorino or parmesan cheese and fresh chopped parsley.
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